Introduction to Embedded Linux

Birth of Free Software

- 1983, Richard Stallman, **GNU project** and the **free software** concept. Beginning of the development of *gcc*, *gdb*, *glibc* and other important tools
- 1991, Linus Torvalds, **Linux kernel project**, a UNIX-like operating system kernel. Together with GNU software and many other open-source components: a completely free operating system, GNU/Linux
- 1995, Linux is more and more popular on server systems
- 2000, Linux is more and more popular on **embedded systems**

Birth of Free Software

- 2008, Linux is more and more popular on mobile devices and phones
- 2012, Linux is available on cheap, extensible hardware: Raspberry Pi, BeagleBone Black

Birth of Free Software

Birth of Free Software

Richard Stallman in 2019 https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Richard_Stallman_at_LibrePlanet_2019.jpg

Free software?

- A program is considered **free** when its license offers to all its users the following **four** freedoms
  - Freedom to run the software for any purpose
  - Freedom to study the software and to change it
  - Freedom to redistribute copies
  - Freedom to distribute copies of modified versions
- These freedoms are granted for both commercial and non-commercial use
- They imply the availability of source code, software can be modified and distributed to customers
- **Good match for embedded systems!**

What is embedded Linux?

Embedded Linux is the usage of the **Linux kernel** and various **open-source** components in embedded systems

Advantages of Linux and Open-Source in embedded systems

- **Ability to reuse components** Many features, protocols and hardware are supported. Allows to focus on the added value of your product.
- **Low cost** No per-unit royalties. Development tools free too. But of course deploying Linux costs time and effort.
- **Full control** You decide when to update components in your system. No vendor lock-in. This secures your investment.
- **Easy testing of new features** No need to negotiate with third-party

Advantages of Linux and Open-Source in embedded systems

vendors. Just explore new solutions released by the community.

- **Quality** Your system is built on high-quality foundations (kernel, compiler, C-library, base utilities...). Many Open-Source applications have good quality too.
- **Security** You can trace the sources of all system components and perform independent vulnerability assessments.
- **Community support** Can get very good support from the community if you approach it with a constructive attitude.

Advantages of Linux and Open-Source in embedded systems

- **Participation in community work**

  Possibility to collaborate with peers and get opportunities beyond corporate barriers.

A few examples of embedded systems running Linux

Wireless routers

Image credits: Evan Amos (https://bit.ly/2JzDIkv)

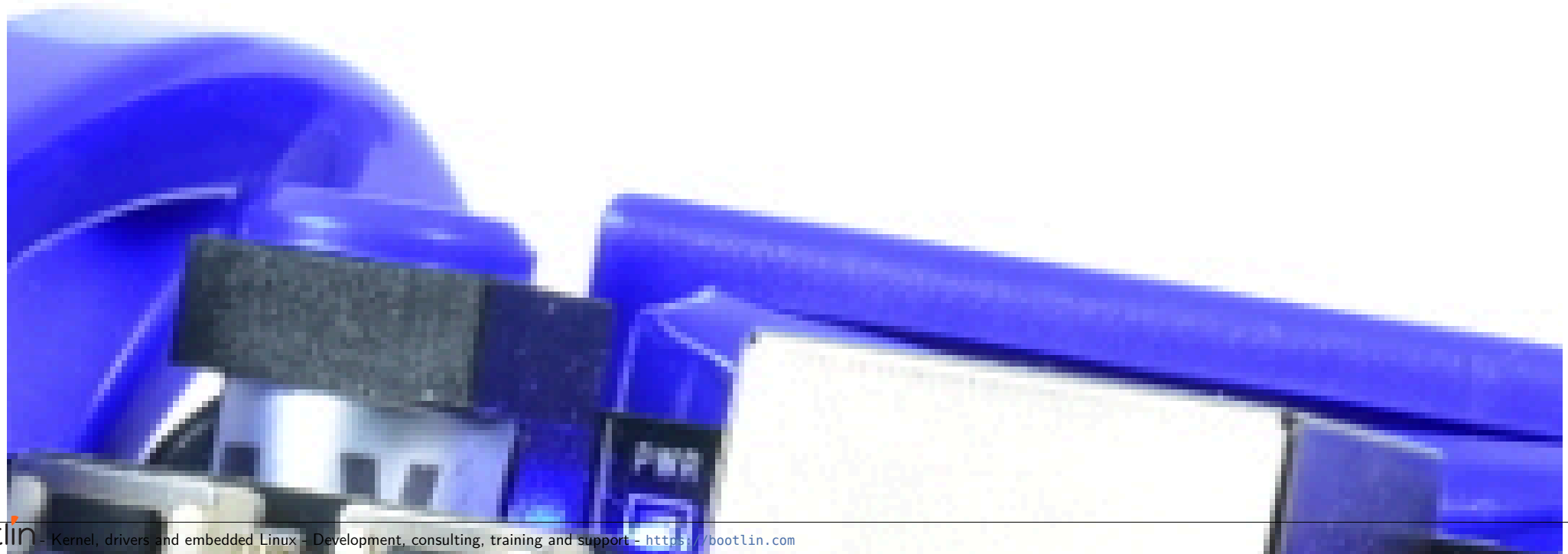
Video systems

Image credits: https://bit.ly/2HbwyVq

Bike computers

Product from BLOKS Permission to use this picture only in this document, in updates and in translations.

Robots



Robots

eduMIP robot (https://www.ucsdrobotics.org/edumip)

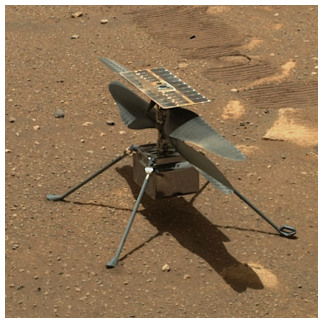
In space

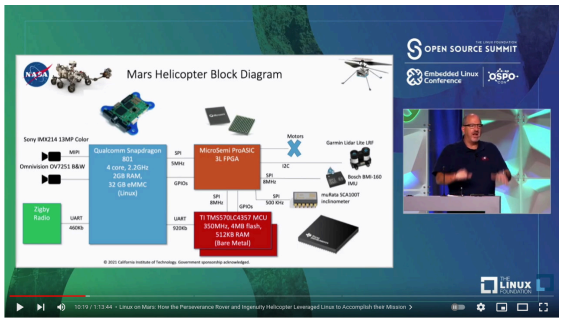
SpaceX Starlink satellites

SpaceX Falcon 9 and Falcon Heavy rockets

Image credits: Wikipedia Mars Ingenuity Helicopter

In space





See the *Linux on Mars: How the Perseverance Rover and Ingenuity Helicopter Leveraged Linux to Accomplish their Mission* presentation from Tim

In space

Canham (JPL, NASA): https://youtu.be/0_GfMcBmbCg?t=111

Embedded hardware for Linux systems

Processor and architecture (1) The Linux kernel and most other

architecture-dependent components support a wide range of 32 and 64 bit architectures

- x86 and x86-64, as found on PC platforms, but also embedded systems (multimedia, industrial)
- ARM, with hundreds of different *System on Chip*s (*SoC*: CPU + on-chip devices, for all sorts of products)
- RISC-V, the rising architecture with a free instruction set (from high-end cloud computing to the smallest embedded systems)
- PowerPC (mainly real-time, industrial applications)
- MIPS (mainly networking applications)
- Microblaze (Xilinx), Nios II (Altera): soft cores on FPGAs
- Others: ARC, m68k, Xtensa, SuperH...

Processor and architecture (2)

- Both MMU and no-MMU architectures are supported, even though no-MMU architectures have a few limitations.
- Linux does not support small microcontrollers (8 or 16 bit)
- Besides the toolchain, the bootloader and the kernel, all other components are generally **architecture-independent**

RAM and storage

- **RAM**: a very basic Linux system can work within 8 MB of RAM, but a more realistic system will usually require at least 32 MB of RAM. Depends on the type and size of applications.
- **Storage**: a very basic Linux system can work within 4 MB of storage, but usually more is needed.
  - **Block storage**: SD/MMC/eMMC, USB mass storage, SATA, etc,
  - **Raw flash storage** is supported too, both NAND and NOR flash, with specific filesystems
- Not necessarily interesting to be too restrictive on the amount of RAM/storage: having flexibility at this level allows to increase performance and re-use as many existing components as possible.

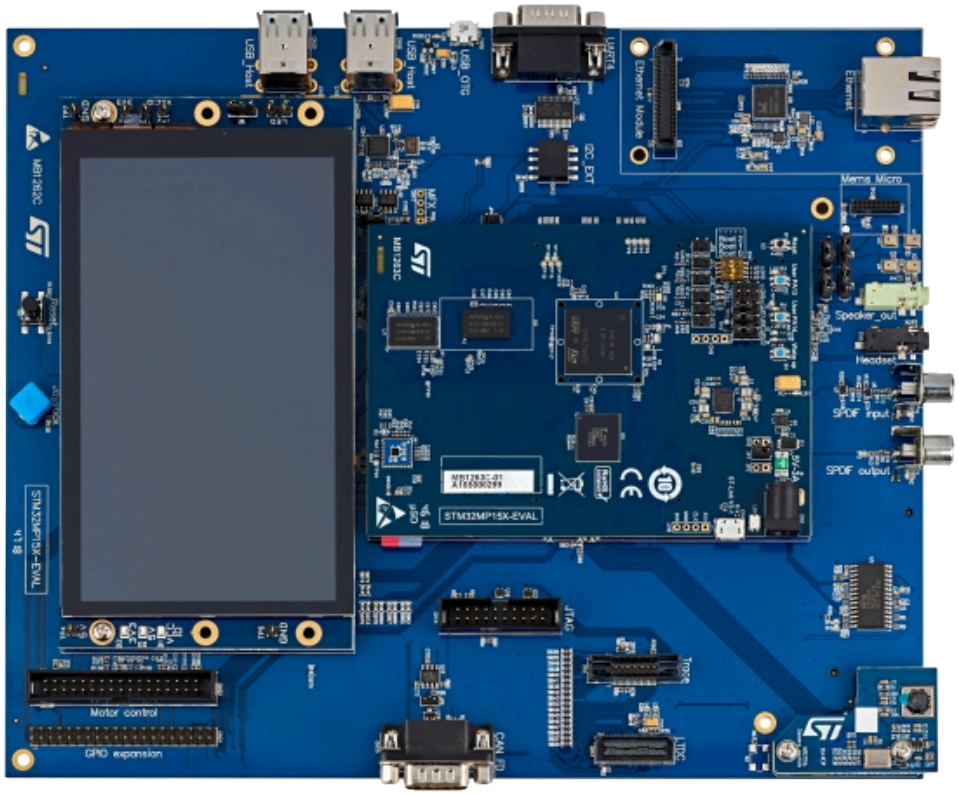
Communication

- The Linux kernel has support for many common communication buses
  - I2C
  - SPI
  - 1-wire
  - SDIO
  - PCI
  - USB
  - CAN (mainly used in automotive)
- And also extensive networking support
  - Ethernet, Wifi, Bluetooth, CAN, etc.
  - IPv4, IPv6, TCP, UDP, etc.
  - Firewalling, advanced routing, multicast

Types of hardware platforms (1)

- **Evaluation platforms** from the SoC vendor. Usually expensive, but many peripherals are built-in. Generally unsuitable for real products, but best for product development.
- **System on Module** (SoM) or **Component on Module**, a small board with only CPU/RAM/flash and a few other core components, with connectors to access all other peripherals. Can be used to build end products for small to medium quantities.

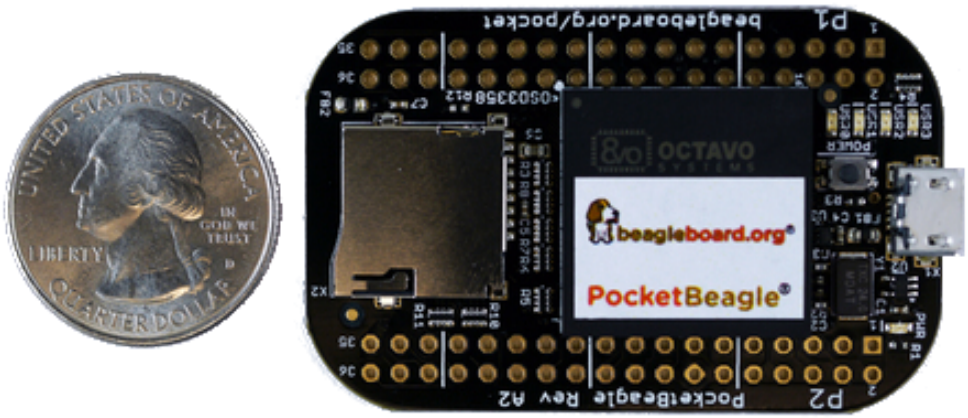
Types of hardware platforms (1)



STM32MP157C-EV1 evaluation board

Image credits

Types of hardware platforms (1)

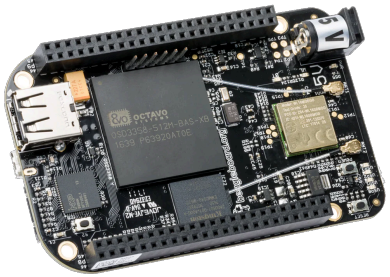


PocketBeagle Image credits (Beagleboard.org): https://beagleboard.org/pocket

Types of hardware platforms (2)

- **Community development platforms**, to make a particular SoC popular and easily available. These are ready-to-use and low cost, but usually have fewer peripherals than evaluation platforms. To some extent, can also be used for real products.
- **Custom platform**. Schematics for evaluation boards or development platforms are more and more commonly freely available, making it easier to develop custom platforms.

Types of hardware platforms (2)



Beaglebone Black Wireless board

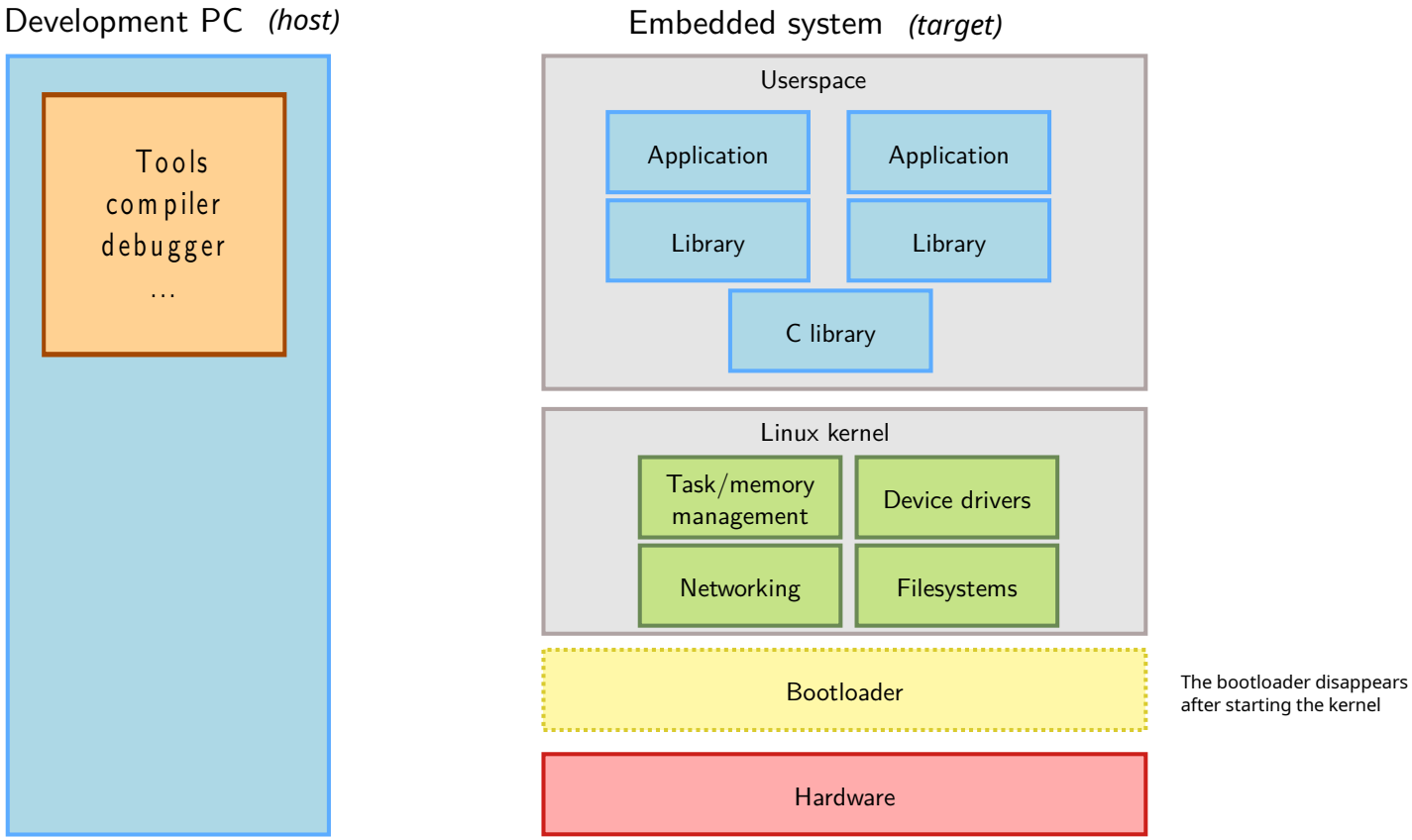
Olimex Open hardware ARM laptop main board Image credits (Olimex): https://www.olimex.com/Products/DIY-Laptop/

Criteria for choosing the hardware

- Most SoCs are delivered with support for the Linux kernel and for an open-source bootloader.
- Having support for your SoC in the official versions of the projects (kernel, bootloader) is a lot better: quality is better, new versions are available, and Long Term Support releases are available.
- Some SoC vendors and/or board vendors do not contribute their changes back to the mainline Linux kernel. Ask them to do so, or use another product if you can. A good measurement is to see the delta between their kernel and the official one.
- **Between properly supported hardware in the official Linux kernel and poorly-supported hardware, there will be huge differences in development time and cost.**

Embedded Linux system architecture

Host and target



Software components

- Cross-compilation toolchain
  - Compiler that runs on the development machine, but generates code for the target
- Bootloader
  - Started by the hardware, responsible for basic initialization, loading and executing the kernel
- Linux Kernel
  - Contains the process and memory management, network stack, device drivers and provides services to user space applications
- C library
  - Of course, a library of C functions
  - Also the interface between the kernel and the user space applications
- Libraries and applications
  - Third-party or in-house

Embedded Linux work

Several distinct tasks are needed when deploying embedded Linux in a product:

- **Board Support Package development**
  - A BSP contains a bootloader and kernel with the suitable device drivers for the targeted hardware
  - Purpose of our *Kernel Development course*
- **System integration**
  - Integrate all the components, bootloader, kernel, third-party libraries and applications and in-house applications into a working system
  - Purpose of *this* course
- **Development of applications**
  - Normal Linux applications, but using specifically chosen libraries